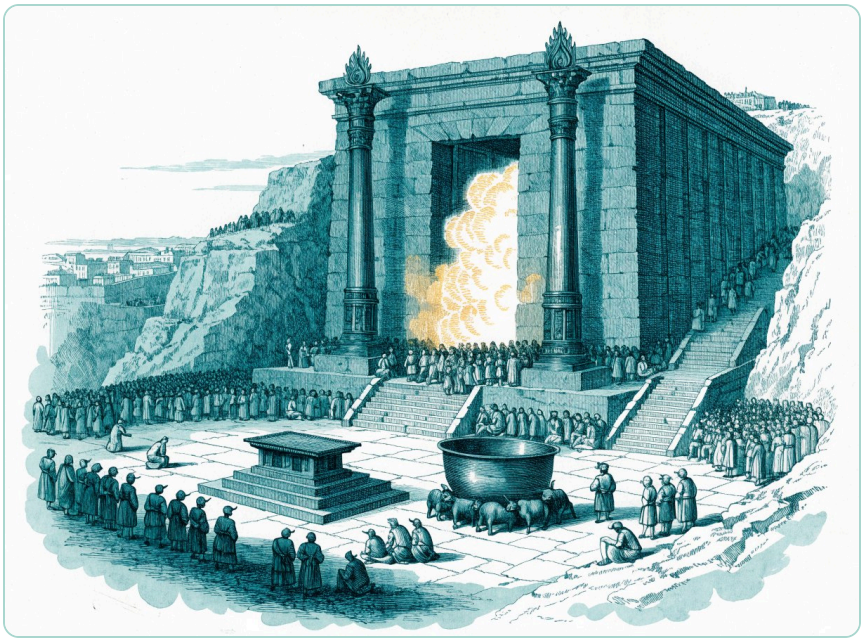
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Solomon and the First Temple

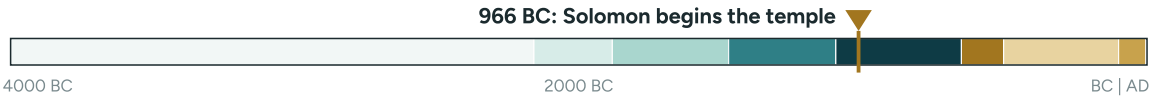
1 Kings 3; 6; 8; 11



David S. Jones

October 18, 2026

YOU ARE HERE · LESSON 15



Introduction: The Golden Age

Lesson 14 ended with God's promise to David: "I will raise up your offspring after you.... He shall build a house for my name" (2 Sam. 7:12–13). This lesson is about that son. His name was Solomon, the son born to David and Bathsheba after their first child died, and the Bible adds a tender note at his birth: "the LORD loved him" (2 Sam. 12:24).

Under Solomon, Israel reached its golden age. The kingdom was at peace. Gold poured in. Rulers came from distant lands to hear his wisdom. And Solomon built the most famous building in Israel's history, the temple in Jerusalem, where the glory of God came down as it had on the tabernacle.

But Solomon's story is also a warning. The wisest king Israel ever had let his heart drift from God, and after his death the kingdom split in two. On our timeline, Solomon reigns from about 970 to 931 BC. He begins the temple in 966 BC, one of the most important dates for the Old Testament timeline, because Scripture ties it directly to the exodus.

The Word: Wisdom

> **Proverbs 9:10** *"The fear of the LORD is the beginning of wisdom, and the knowledge of the Holy One is insight."*

חָכְמָה *(chokmah, "wisdom")*

skill for living: knowing how to live well in God's world

Skill

Ex. 31:3

The Hebrew word behind "ability" in Exodus 31:3 describes Bezalel's craftsmanship on the tabernacle (Lesson 10).

\+

Discernment

1 Kings 3:9, 28

Telling right from wrong, and true from false, in real decisions.

\+

Fear of the LORD

Prov. 9:10

Reverence for God is where real wisdom begins.

Payoff: Biblical wisdom is not mainly about being clever. It is knowing how to live well because you know God. The New Testament says Christ himself is "the wisdom of God" (1 Cor. 1:24), the one "in whom are hidden all the treasures of wisdom and knowledge" (Col. 2:3). Solomon had wisdom. Jesus *is* wisdom.

Part One: A King Asks for Wisdom

Early in his reign, God appeared to Solomon in a dream and made an astonishing offer: "Ask what I shall give you" (1 Kings 3:5). Solomon could have asked for anything. He knew he was in over his head: "I am but a little child. I do not know how to go out or come in." So he asked, "Give your servant therefore an understanding mind to govern your people, that I may discern between good and evil" (3:7, 9).

God was pleased. Because Solomon had not asked for long life or riches or the death of his enemies, God gave him wisdom, and riches and honor besides (3:11–13). Soon a hard case came before the new king. Two women lived in one house, and each had a baby. One baby died in the night, and now both women claimed the living child. There were no witnesses. Solomon called for a sword and ordered the living baby cut in two, half for each woman. One woman said, go ahead. The other cried out, give her the child, only do not kill him. Solomon knew at once that the woman willing to lose her son to save his life was the real mother (3:16–27). "And all Israel heard of the judgment that the king had rendered," and they saw "that the wisdom of God was in him to do justice" (3:28).



"They perceived that the wisdom of God was in him to do justice" (1 Kings 3:28).

Solomon's wisdom became world famous. He spoke three thousand proverbs and over a thousand songs, and "people of all nations came to hear the wisdom of Solomon" (4:32, 34). Much of the book of Proverbs comes from him. The same God offers wisdom to you: "If any of you lacks wisdom, let him ask God, who gives generously to all without reproach, and it will be given him" (James 1:5).

Part Two: Building God's House

Then Solomon built the temple. The Bible dates it with unusual precision: "In the four hundred and eightieth year after the people of Israel came out of the land of Egypt, in the fourth year of Solomon's reign over Israel… he began to build the house of the LORD" (1 Kings 6:1). That verse is one of the main anchors for the dates in this series. Count back 480 years from 966 BC and you reach the exodus in about 1446 BC.

Where did he build it? "On Mount Moriah" (2 Chr. 3:1). That name should ring a bell. Abraham took Isaac to "the land of Moriah" to sacrifice him, and there God provided a ram in his place (Gen. 22:2, 13; Lesson 6). Chronicles uses the same name on purpose: about a thousand years later, on Mount Moriah, Israel's altar would burn day after day.

The temple followed the plan of the tabernacle, but larger and permanent: a courtyard with a great bronze altar and a huge bronze basin called "the sea," resting on twelve bronze oxen (7:23–25), a Holy Place, and an inner room, the Most Holy Place, a perfect cube "twenty cubits long, twenty cubits wide, and twenty cubits high" (about 30 feet each way), overlaid with pure gold (6:20). It took seven years to build (6:38).

From Tent to Temple

	THE TABERNACLE	SOLOMON'S TEMPLE
Built	About 1445 BC (Ex. 40:17)	966–959 BC (1 Kings 6:1, 38)
Where	Moved with Israel	Mount Moriah, Jerusalem (2 Chr. 3:1)
Made of	Wood, gold, curtains	Stone, cedar, gold
Most Holy Place	A small inner room	A 20-cubit cube of gold (6:20)
Builders	Bezalel, filled with the Spirit	Solomon, with craftsmen from Hiram of Tyre
Glory	The cloud filled it (Ex. 40:34)	The cloud filled it (1 Kings 8:10–11)
End	Brought into the temple (1 Kings 8:4)	Burned by Babylon, 586 BC

Same plan, same glory: God dwelling among his people.

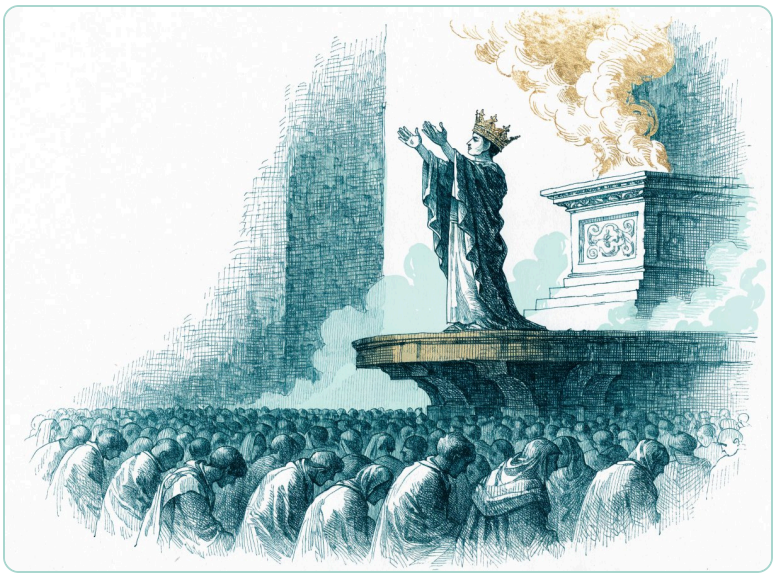
While Solomon was building, God reminded him that a beautiful building could never take the place of a faithful heart: "if you will walk in my statutes and obey my rules and keep all my commandments… I will dwell among the children of Israel and will not forsake my people Israel" (6:12–13). God's presence was always a gift of grace, and grace calls for a faithful response.

Part Three: The Glory Fills the House

When the temple was finished, the priests carried the ark of the covenant into the Most Holy Place, "underneath the wings of the cherubim" (8:6). And then it happened again, just as it had at the tabernacle (Lesson 10):

> **1 Kings 8:10–11** *"And when the priests came out of the Holy Place, a cloud filled the house of the LORD, so that the priests could not stand to minister because of the cloud, for the glory of the LORD filled the house of the LORD."*

Then Solomon stood before the altar, "spread out his hands toward heaven" (8:22), and prayed one of the great prayers of the Bible. In the middle of the most magnificent building Israel ever built, he said something remarkably humble:



Solomon "spread out his hands toward heaven" (1 Kings 8:22).

> **1 Kings 8:27** *"But will God indeed dwell on the earth? Behold, heaven and the highest heaven cannot contain you; how much less this house that I have built!"*

Solomon knew that no building could hold God. The temple was a meeting place, the place where God had promised, "My name shall be there" (8:29). So Solomon asked God to hear every prayer prayed toward it. He prayed for Israel when they sinned and were defeated, when drought came, when sickness struck. He even prayed for foreigners: "when a foreigner, who is not of your people Israel, comes from a far country for your name's sake… hear in heaven… in order that all the peoples of the earth may know your name" (8:41–43). And looking far ahead, he prayed for a day when Israel might be carried off into exile for their sins: if they repented there, would God hear and forgive (8:46–50)? That day would come, as we will see in Lesson 18.

When he finished, "fire came down from heaven and consumed the burnt offering and the sacrifices, and the glory of the LORD filled the temple," and the people fell on their faces and worshiped: "For he is good, for his steadfast love endures forever" (2 Chr. 7:1, 3). Solomon blessed the people with words that echo Joshua 21:45: "Not one word has failed of all his good promise" (1 Kings 8:56).

Part Four: The Wise King's Foolish Heart

If you only read the first half of Solomon's story, you would think he was the promised King. Read on, and you find out he was not.

Hundreds of years earlier, God had set three limits on Israel's future kings. A king must not multiply horses, especially from Egypt. He must not multiply wives, "lest his heart turn away." And he must not pile up silver and gold for himself (Deut. 17:16–17). Solomon broke all three. He imported horses and

chariots from Egypt (1 Kings 10:26–29). Gold flowed in by the ton (10:14). And "he had 700 wives, who were princesses, and 300 concubines. And his wives turned away his heart" (11:3).

The King's Law and the Wise King

GOD'S LIMITS FOR KINGS (DEUT. 17:16–17)	WHAT SOLOMON DID (1 KINGS 10–11)
HORSES Do not multiply horses or send to Egypt for them	**HORSES** Imported horses and chariots from Egypt (10:26–29)
WIVES Do not multiply wives, lest his heart turn away	**WIVES** 700 wives and 300 concubines; "his wives turned away his heart" (11:3)
GOLD Do not pile up silver and gold	**GOLD** 666 talents (about 25 tons) of gold in one year (10:14)

"His heart was not wholly true to the LORD his God" (1 Kings 11:4).

The drift was slow. "When Solomon was old his wives turned away his heart after other gods, and his heart was not wholly true to the LORD his God" (11:4). The man who built God's temple built shrines for the gods of his wives on the hill east of Jerusalem, even for Molech, the god whose worshipers burned their children in the fire (11:7; see Lev. 18:21; 2 Kings 23:10). "And the LORD was angry with Solomon, because his heart had turned away from the LORD, the God of Israel, who had appeared to him twice" (11:9).

God told Solomon the kingdom would be torn from his son. Yet even in judgment he kept his promise to David: one tribe would remain for David's sake (11:11–13). After Solomon died in 931 BC, the ten northern tribes broke away, crying, "What portion do we have in David?… To your tents, O Israel!" (12:16). The golden age lasted one generation. Wisdom, wealth, and even a temple could not keep a heart faithful.

THREAD WATCH

THE LAMB The temple stood on Mount Moriah, where God provided a ram in Isaac's place (Gen. 22). For nearly a thousand years, lambs and bulls died on that mountain. Nearby, outside the city walls, another Son would one day be offered, and this time no substitute would take his place. He was the substitute.

GOD WITH HIS PEOPLE The cloud of glory filled Solomon's temple as it filled the tabernacle. But Solomon admitted that even the highest heaven cannot contain God. And God warned that if Israel turned away, "this house will become a heap of ruins" (9:8). In 586 BC the Babylonians burned it (2 Kings 25:9). God's dwelling with his people would need a better temple.

The Turn: Something Greater Than Solomon

The Queen of Sheba traveled from the far south of Arabia, well over a thousand miles, to hear Solomon's wisdom (1 Kings 10:1–9). Jesus pointed to her and said, "behold, something greater than Solomon is here" (Matt. 12:42). Solomon asked God for wisdom. Jesus is the answer to that prayer in person. "Because of him you are in Christ Jesus, who became to us wisdom from God, righteousness and sanctification and redemption" (1 Cor. 1:30).

Solomon built a temple of stone. Jesus said, "Destroy this temple, and in three days I will raise it up," and John explains, "he was speaking about the temple of his body" (John 2:19, 21). Solomon's temple was burned to the ground, and even the temple rebuilt after it was destroyed in its turn. The temple of Jesus' body was destroyed on the cross and rose on the third day, never to die again. He is where God now meets his people. That is why Jesus told a Samaritan woman, "the hour is coming, and is now here, when the true worshipers will worship the Father in spirit and truth" (John 4:23). You do not have to travel to Jerusalem. You come to Jesus. And all who come to him become "living stones… being built up as a spiritual house" (1 Pet. 2:5).

Solomon's heart turned away when he was old. Jesus' heart never turned. He is the Son of David whom God promised, the one who builds God's house and whose throne lasts forever. Solomon prayed that foreigners from far countries would come and pray toward God's house. Through Jesus, they have, from every nation on earth.

Solomon's story asks you an honest question: what is slowly turning your heart? It rarely happens all at once. Ask God for wisdom, and he will give it. But the wisdom you need most is a Person. Jesus forgives drifting hearts and holds on to the people he saves. Come to the One who is greater than Solomon, and let him turn your heart back.

Living It: Six Practices for This Week

1. **Ask for wisdom.** Name one decision you are facing. Pray James 1:5 over it every day this week.
2. **Read a proverb a day.** There are thirty-one chapters in Proverbs. Read the one that matches today's date.
3. **Pray Solomon's prayer.** Read 1 Kings 8:22–30 aloud. Thank God that you can pray to him anywhere, through Jesus.
4. **Watch for slow drift.** What small compromise, repeated over time, could turn your heart? Name it and bring it to God.
5. **Worship together.** Gather with God's people this Sunday as living stones in his house (1 Pet. 2:5).
6. **Memorize Proverbs 9:10.** "The fear of the LORD is the beginning of wisdom, and the knowledge of the Holy One is insight."

Before Lesson 16: *Read 1 Kings 12, 17–19, and 2 Kings 17. Lesson 16 follows the divided kingdom and the prophets God sent, especially Elijah, to call his people back.*

For Discussion

1. If God said to you, “Ask what I shall give you,” what would you honestly ask for? What does Solomon’s request teach you?
2. Proverbs says the fear of the LORD is the beginning of wisdom. How is that different from simply being smart?
3. The temple stood on Mount Moriah. Why does that connection to Abraham and Isaac matter?
4. Solomon said heaven cannot contain God, yet God promised to put his name in the temple. How can both be true?
5. Solomon broke all three of the king’s limits in Deuteronomy 17: horses (military power), wives (sex and romance), and gold (money). Which of these pulls hardest on hearts today?
6. Solomon’s heart turned away slowly, “when Solomon was old.” What helps a heart stay faithful over a lifetime?
7. Jesus said “something greater than Solomon is here.” In what ways is Jesus greater?

Sources & For Further Study

- On חָכְמָה: Brown, Driver, and Briggs, *Hebrew and English Lexicon*, s.v.; Bruce K. Waltke, *The Book of Proverbs* (NICOT), introduction.
- On 1 Kings 6:1 and biblical chronology: Eugene H. Merrill, *Kingdom of Priests*. On the temple: G. K. Beale, *The Temple and the Church’s Mission*.
- For further reading: Dale Ralph Davis, *1 Kings: The Wisdom and the Folly*; Philip Graham Ryken, *1 Kings* (Reformed Expository Commentary).



David S. Jones

Author of *Seventy Times Seven: On the God Who Forgives Past All Counting*. He teaches Scripture every week or so at 490.life, serves on the worship teams at Scottsdale Bible Church, and serves in the men’s group, The Forge, helping to disciple men and pointing them to Jesus. He coaches and mentors men one-to-one and speaks to churches and men’s groups.

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